

By the mid-16th century, Reformation ideas had been widely disseminated. Lutheranism spread across Germany and Scandinavia; Calvinism took hold in much of Switzerland, and made significant inroads in Scotland. There were also Calvinists in France, where they were called Huguenots, although that country was split between Catholics and Protestants, who fought in the Wars of Religion of the second half of the 16th century. Spain, Portugal, and Italy remained Catholic.

In England, the seeds of reform were sown early. Many people objected to abuses such as the use of church funds to pay for clerics—including the Pope and foreign bishops—to lead a life of luxury. However, Protestant ideas were not yet widely enough held for the faith to take hold. Things changed when Henry VIII of England broke with Rome in 1534, rejecting papal authority and proclaiming himself head of the church in England. As supreme ecclesiastical leader, he exercised his sole right to authorize the publication of the English Bible, the Coverdale Bible, but English religious practice and doctrine remained Catholic. A moderate form of Protestantism was later established in England under Henry's daughter Elizabeth I.

Reformers risked their lives by speaking out at a time when heresy was punishable by death. Czech reformer Jan Hus had been burned at the stake in 1415, Zwingli died in a battle between Protestant and Catholic

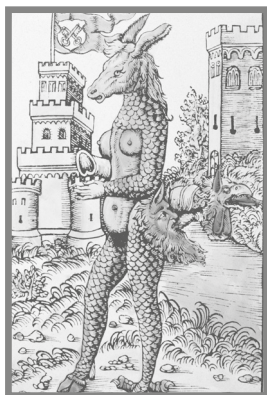
forces in 1531, and English Bible translator William Tyndale was executed in 1536.

Luther, urged to recant by Pope Leo X in 1520, threw the written request on a bonfire, so church authorities handed him over to Frederick the Wise, Elector of Saxony and founder of the University of Wittenberg, for punishment. Frederick convened a formal inquiry or "Diet" at Worms, at which Emperor Charles V presided. The emperor rejected Luther's arguments and banned his views in the empire, but Luther refused to recant. He was outlawed and excommunicated, but Frederick saved him from execution by faking his abduction, then hiding him at the Wartburg castle. Luther continued to write and organize, garnering increasing support.

Powerful allies

Support from people in positions of power assisted the spread of the Reformation. Like Henry VIII in England, the princes of Germany resented church wealth, taxation, and its independent law courts, and were also eager to strengthen their own power. Throughout the Middle Ages, popes had made alliances with kings and emperors, and intervened in secular affairs. Many German princes wanted to prevent such alliances by cutting ties with Rome and removing bishops from their princedoms, so their support for the reformers was motivated by political expedience as well as personal piety.

In what would become the first in a long list of religiously motivated conflicts between Catholics and Protestants, the Holy Roman Emperor Charles V invaded Lutheran territory in an effort to stamp out the movement. Lutherans united against him and, despite his triumph at the Battle of Mühlberg in 1547, he was unable to suppress them. A temporary compromise was eventually reached at Augsburg in 1555 when the emperor conceded that each prince within the empire could choose how to worship in his own domain. The peace was not to last, however; bitter divisions drawn by the Reformation would cause people across Europe to take up arms again, and the continent was ravaged by more than a century of religiously-motivated conflict.



Cartoon images of the pope as a bestial monstrosity communicated to an international audience, literate and not, a common Protestant idea that the papacy was the institution of the devil.